"If I had been better, they would not have left."

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Where it often comes from

When someone leaves a marriage, a friendship, or a family, we look for the reason, and we often settle on ourselves because that gives us a sense of control. If only I had been more attractive, more patient, more successful, then they would have stayed. The belief can hold us in guilt long after the relationship has ended.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says, "Each of us will give an account of himself to God." Another person's choice to leave is theirs. God's own heart on broken faith is clear: "So guard yourselves in your spirit and do not break faith." The psalmist says, "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted," and "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds." We can honestly look at our part, make changes, and still know that we could not have forced anyone to stay. Better would not have guaranteed that they would remain.

> *"So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God"* (Romans 14:12).

Also see

> "If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone" (Romans 12:18).

> "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit" (Psalm 34:18).

> "'For I hate divorce,' says the LORD, the God of Israel. 'He who divorces his wife covers his garment with violence,' says the LORD of Hosts. So guard yourselves in your spirit and do not break faith" (Malachi 2:16).

> "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds" (Psalm 147:3).

Common self-statements

- It is my fault they left.
- If I had changed, they would be here.
- I drove them away.
- I was not good enough.
- I should have done more.
- Everything would be different if I were different.

Common logical errors

- Personalization: Treating another person's choice as my responsibility.
- Hindsight bias: Believing I should have known what to do.
- Magical thinking: Believing the right behavior would have guaranteed their staying.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty and concluding that I am to blame.

Challenging questions

- What would I have had to do, and is it realistic to think it would have worked?
- What responsibility did the other person have for their choices?
- What do I know now that I did not know then?
- Where do I need to own real mistakes and ask forgiveness?

- What does it mean that “each of us will give an account of himself”?
- What would I tell a friend who said this?

Truth summary

> I can own my real mistakes without taking responsibility for another person’s choice to leave. I could not have forced them to stay, and my worth does not depend on their decision. I can learn, grieve, and heal.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Divorce
- Guilt/Shame
- Forgiveness
- Grief
- Hardship

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Trouble/Hardship

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

The God Who Stays — Matthew West
God’s faithful presence challenges the expectation of rejection and abandonment.

Softly and Tenderly — Kristyn Getty with Vince Gill, Ellie Holcomb and Sierra Hull
This older hymn pictures Christ’s gracious invitation to return rather than hide in shame.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

My Plan for Replacing "If I had been better, they would not have left"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I had been better, they would not have left." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What was mine to own?
- ☐ What was theirs?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend?
- ☐ What can I learn?
- ☐ Who can I grieve with?
- ☐ What do I need to forgive?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Each person answers for their own choices.
- ☐ I could not have forced anyone to stay.
- ☐ I can own my part without owning theirs.
- ☐ The Lord is near to the brokenhearted.
- ☐ He heals my wounds.
- ☐ My worth does not depend on their decision.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Romans 14:12
  "So then, each of us will give an account of himself to God."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Psalm 147:3
  "He heals the brokenhearted and binds up their wounds."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Mine and theirs: Each week, list one thing that was mine to own and one thing that was theirs.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Romans 14:12 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Each of us answers for our own choices, and I could not force them to stay.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Divorce" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Divide the responsibility. Make two columns of what was mine and what was theirs.
- [ ] Seek forgiveness where due. Confess real mistakes to God and, if appropriate, to others.
- [ ] Grieve. Allow sadness with a trusted listener or counselor.
- [ ] Say Romans 14:12 aloud. Remind yourself that you answer for you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I had been better, they would not have left": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Mine and theirs
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I had been better, they would not have left.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I replay what I could have done. Show me what is mine to own and what is not. Forgive me where I failed and heal the wound of being left. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.